Joaquín Paleo

Department of Economics, University of California, Davis
jmpaleo@ucdavis.edu · joaquinpaleo.github.io

Education

Ph.D. in Economics, University of California, Davis — expected 2027
M.A. in Economics, Universidad de la República, Uruguay — 2021
Thesis: *The Allocation of Houses within Housing Cooperatives: A Market Design Approach*
Licenciatura en Economía (B.A.), Universidad de la República, Uruguay — 2019

Research Fields

Primary: Labor Economics, Economics of Education. Secondary: Applied Microeconomics.

Job Market Paper

Grades, Academic Performance, and Labor Market Outcomes
with Mathías Fondo and Rodrigo Nicolau

Abstract: Grades open doors to scholarships, graduate programs, and jobs, but distinguishing the effect of grades from the underlying ability they measure is hard. We study this question by implementing a Regression Discontinuity Design around grade-jump cutoffs at Uruguay's main higher education institution, where a deterministic rule converts continuous course scores into coarser transcript grades. Marginally earning a higher first-semester grade raises next-semester GPA by 0.23 standard deviations. Because students observe both the score and the grade, the response reflects the transcript label rather than anything students learn about their own ability. In the labor market, monthly earnings at the first job show no detectable change. In contrast, hourly wages are 17 to 21 percent higher, while weekly hours worked are 2.2 to 2.8 hours lower. The wage premium fades quickly, but the hours reduction persists. These findings seem to be driven by within-industry changes, rather than students sorting across industries with systematically different jobs. A higher grade also raises public-sector entry by 7 percentage points, where hiring rules score GPA explicitly. Finally, among students who start working after the grade is realized, we find evidence that academic performance improves in the semesters after the first job begins, relative to students who marginally earned a lower grade, which is consistent with them working fewer hours.

Working Papers

Unionization and College Enrollment: Evidence from Close Union Elections

Work in Progress

Information about Relative Performance and Future Academic Achievement
with Mathías Fondo and Rodrigo Nicolau
The Short-Run Effects of Mexican-American School Desegregation

Presentations

2026: Southern Economic Association Annual Meeting (scheduled); All-California Labor Economics Conference; UC Davis Applied Microeconomics Seminar; UC Davis Alumni Conference (Poster)
2025: All-California Labor Economics Conference (Poster); UC Davis internal seminars (2)

Teaching Experience

University of California, Davis

Associate Instructor (instructor of record)

Industrial Organization (ECN 121A)	Spring 2027 (scheduled)

Teaching Assistant

Intermediate Micro Theory: Consumer and Producer Theory (ECN 100A)	Su 2024, F 2024, W 2025, Sp 2025
Intermediate Micro Theory: Imperfect Competition and Market Failure (ECN 100B)	W 2026
Theory of Games and Strategic Behavior (ECN 122)	Su 2023, F 2023, Sp 2024
Economics of Uncertainty and Information (ECN 103)	F 2022, W 2023
Public Microeconomics (ECN 130)	Sp 2026
Decision Making (ECN 106)	W 2024
Industrial Organization (ECN 121A)	Su 2023
Principles of Microeconomics (ECN 1A)	Sp 2023

Reader

International Economic Relations (ECN 162)	F 2026

Research Experience

Graduate Student Researcher, University of California, Davis	Summer 2026
Research Fellow (Initiation to Research Program), Universidad de la República, Montevideo	2020 – 2021
Research Assistant, Instituto de Economía, Universidad de la República	Jan – May 2020
Assistant, Statistics Unit, Ministerio de Trabajo y Seguridad Social, Montevideo	2019

Awards and Fellowships

Department Travel Award, University of California, Davis	2024
Best Master's Thesis Award, Sociedad de Economistas del Uruguay	2021
Provost's First Year Fellowship, University of California, Davis	2021
Initiation to Research Fellowship, Universidad de la República	2020

Other Information

Languages: Spanish (native), English (fluent)

Software: Stata, Python, R, LaTeX

Citizenship: Uruguayan and Spanish